



# Visualizing genus zero dessins

Mike Musty   ICERM 2025   August 12, 2025



## Background

- Number theory, computation

## Past

- Postdoc (ICERM)
- Mathematician (CRREL)
  - Computer vision, mixed models

## Current

- Data wrangler (Faraday)
  - Product implementation
  - Modeling / API infrastructure
  - Client solutions
- Toddler wrangler

# Outline



1. Drawings
2. Background
3. Visualizations old and new
4. Examples and motivating questions

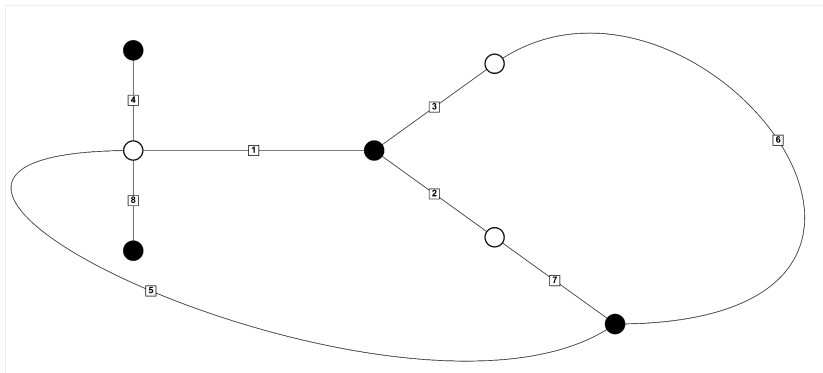
# Drawing example



$\sigma_0 = (1,4,5,8)(2,7)(3,6)$ ,  $\sigma_1 = (1,2,3)(5,6,7)$ ,  $\sigma_\infty = (8,7,1)(6,2)(5,4,3)$

Base field:  $1 - 3T^2$

Embedding: -1.732051

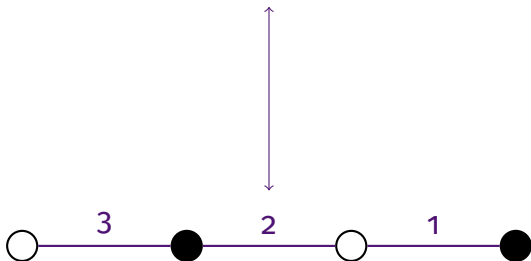


8T38-4.2.2\_3.3.1.1\_3.3.2

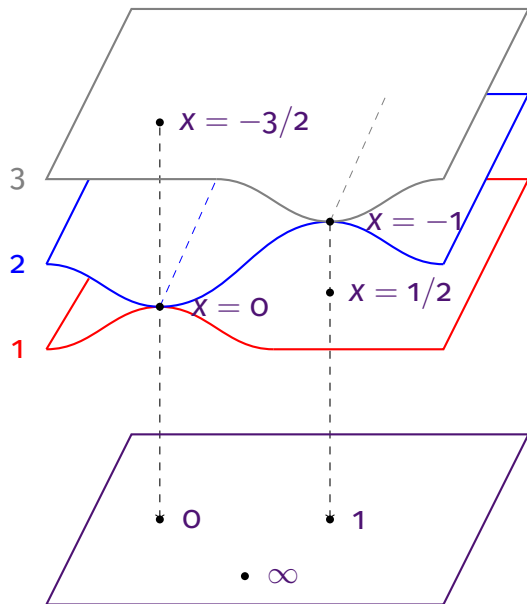
# Degree 3 example



$$\left( (12)(3), (1)(23), (132) \right)$$



# Degree 3 example



$$\begin{aligned} \varphi(x) &= \underbrace{2x^3 + 3x^2}_z \\ &= x^2(2x + 3) \\ &= (2x - 1)(x + 1)^2 + 1 \end{aligned}$$

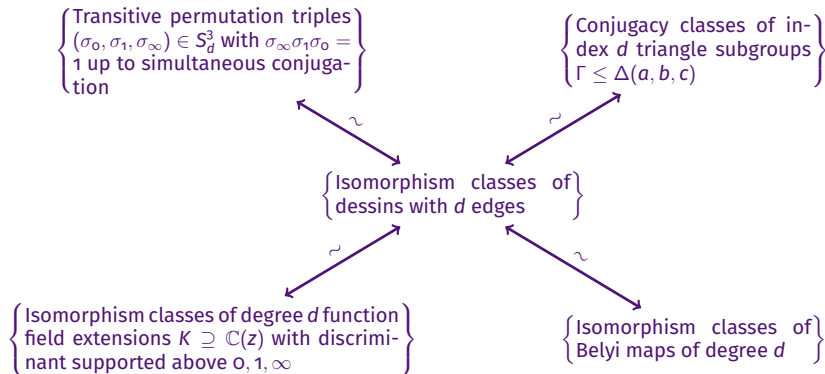
$\mathbb{P}^1$

# Belyi maps, dessins, etc.



- This branched covering is an example of a **Belyi map**, a map of Riemann surfaces unbranched outside of  $0, 1, \infty$ .
- A Belyi map determines a **permutation triple** via monodromy.
- A permutation triple determines a **triangle subgroup**  $\Gamma$  which acts on a spherical, Euclidean, or hyperbolic space  $\mathcal{H}$  such that  $\Gamma \backslash \mathcal{H} \rightarrow \Delta \backslash \mathcal{H}$  is the corresponding Belyi map.
- The preimage of  $[0, 1]$  is a (connected) bipartite graph embedded on a surface called a **dessin d'enfant**.

# Equivalent categories



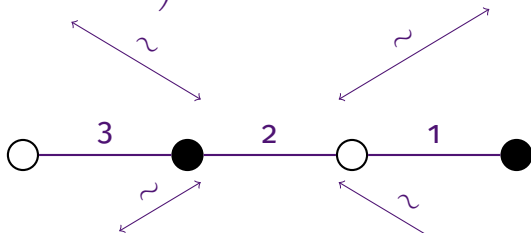


# Degree 3 example



$$((12)(3), (1)(23), (132))$$

$$[\Delta(2, 2, 3) : \Gamma] = 3$$



$$\mathbb{C} \left( \underbrace{2x^3 + 3x^2}_z \right) \subseteq \mathbb{C}(x)$$

$$\varphi(x) = \underbrace{2x^3 + 3x^2}_z$$



## Theorem (Belyi, 1979)

*A smooth projective curve  $X$  over  $\mathbb{C}$  can be defined over  $\overline{\mathbb{Q}}$  if and only if there exists a nonconstant morphism of algebraic curves  $\varphi : X \rightarrow \mathbb{P}^1$  unramified outside  $\{0, 1, \infty\}$ .*

In the 1980s Grothendieck described an action of the absolute Galois group  $\text{Gal}(\overline{\mathbb{Q}}/\mathbb{Q})$  on the set of (isomorphism classes of) dessins.

# Passports



A **passport** consists of the data  $(G, \lambda)$  where

- $G \leq S_d$  is a transitive subgroup
- $\lambda = (\lambda_0, \lambda_1, \lambda_\infty)$  is a triple of partitions of  $d$

A permutation triple  $\sigma \in S_d^3$  **belongs** to  $(G, \lambda)$  if

- $\langle \sigma_0, \sigma_1, \sigma_\infty \rangle = G$
- $\sigma_0, \sigma_1, \sigma_\infty$  have the cycle types specified by  $\lambda_0, \lambda_1, \lambda_\infty$

Note

- The **size** of a passport is the number of permutation triples belonging to it (up to simultaneous conjugacy).
- A **refined passport** replaces  $\lambda$  with  $C = (C_0, C_1, C_\infty)$  a triple of conjugacy classes of  $G$ .
- Passports and refined passports are stable under the Galois action and therefore are unions of Galois orbits.

# Objective of this work



Draw topologically correct dessins to help visualize the Galois orbits of all (genus zero) passports in the LMFDB.

- <https://www.lmfdb.org/Belyi/>
- <https://michaelmusty.github.io/dessins/>



- <https://www.lmfdb.org/Belyi/7T6/5.1.1/4.2.1/3.2.2/>
- [https://michaelmusty.github.io/dessins/passports/7T6-5.1.1\\_4.2.1\\_3.2.2/index.html](https://michaelmusty.github.io/dessins/passports/7T6-5.1.1_4.2.1_3.2.2/index.html)
- All drawings together



- <https://www.lmfdb.org/Belyi/5T4/5/5/3.1.1/>
- [https://michaelmusty.github.io/dessins/passports/5T4-5\\_5\\_3.1.1/index.html](https://michaelmusty.github.io/dessins/passports/5T4-5_5_3.1.1/index.html)
- All drawings together



- <https://www.lmfdb.org/Belyi/9T34/6.1.1.1/5.2.2/6.1.1.1/>
- [https://michaelmusty.github.io/dessins/passports/9T34-6.1.1.1\\_5.2.2\\_6.1.1.1/index.html](https://michaelmusty.github.io/dessins/passports/9T34-6.1.1.1_5.2.2_6.1.1.1/index.html)
- All drawings together

# Motivating future questions



The ultimate goal is to learn something about the absolute Galois group through its action on dessins. To that end:

- Can we tell when 2 dessins correspond to Galois conjugate Belyi maps?
- Is there topological or combinatorial data that can tell us when a passport splits into multiple Galois orbits?
- Can we determine the Galois orbits given a set of representatives for a passport?



# Completeness of the data



| $d \backslash g$ | 0       | 1       | 2      | 3    | $\geq 4$ | total     |
|------------------|---------|---------|--------|------|----------|-----------|
| 1                | 1/1     | 0       | 0      | 0    | 0        | 1/1       |
| 2                | 1/1     | 0       | 0      | 0    | 0        | 1/1       |
| 3                | 2/2     | 1/1     | 0      | 0    | 0        | 3/3       |
| 4                | 6/6     | 2/2     | 0      | 0    | 0        | 8/8       |
| 5                | 12/12   | 6/6     | 2/2    | 0    | 0        | 20/20     |
| 6                | 38/38   | 29/29   | 7/7    | 0    | 0        | 74/74     |
| 7                | 89/89   | 50/50   | 7/13   | 2/3  | 0        | 148/155   |
| 8                | 243/261 | 83/217  | 0/84   | 0/11 | 0        | 326/573   |
| 9                | 410/583 | 33/427  | 0/163  | 0/28 | 0/6      | 443/1207  |
| total            | 802/993 | 204/732 | 16/269 | 2/42 | 0/6      | 1024/2042 |

# Thanks!



To:

- Sam Schiavone  
<https://math.mit.edu/~sschiavo/>
- Aaron Fenyes <https://ooo.fareycircles.ooo/>
- And to you for listening!